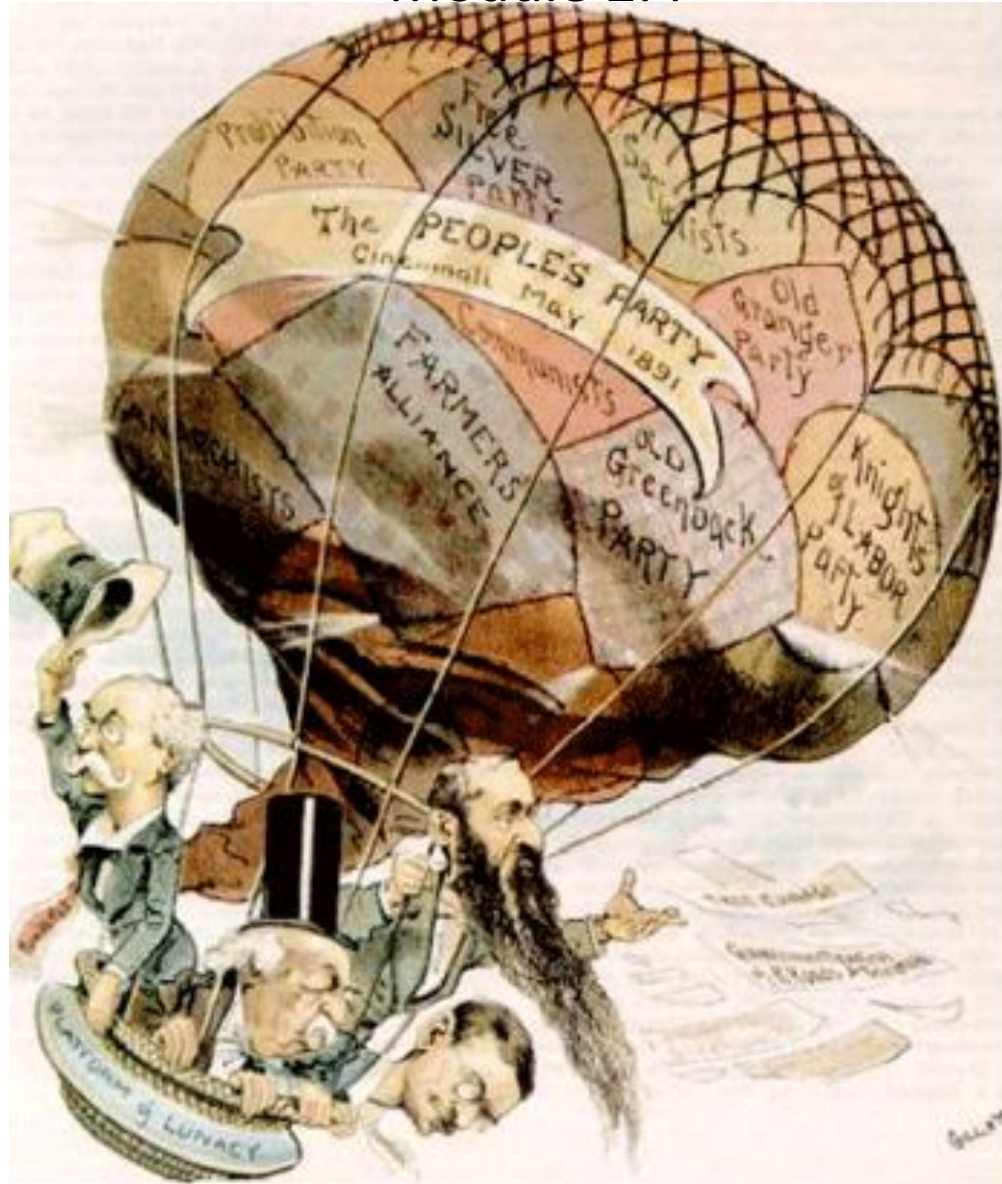


Farmers & Populist Movement

Module 2.4



"A Party of Patches," JUNE MAGAZINE, JUNE 8, 1891

What are some issues/problems do you think farmers faced in the late 1800s in the United States?



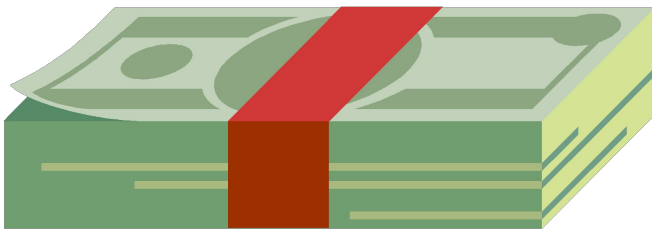
Economic Problems of Farmers

Good farmland
is scarce



Money Supply





Economics Nationwide

- Greenbacks?
 - put into circulation and increased money supply
 - Paper Money
 - Not Hard Money-backed by coin
- Farmers took out loans during this time
- Problem with greenbacks?
Could not be exchanged for gold or silver. Was worth less than hard \$
- When government took back the greenbacks after the Civil War, people had to pay back loans in more expensive money



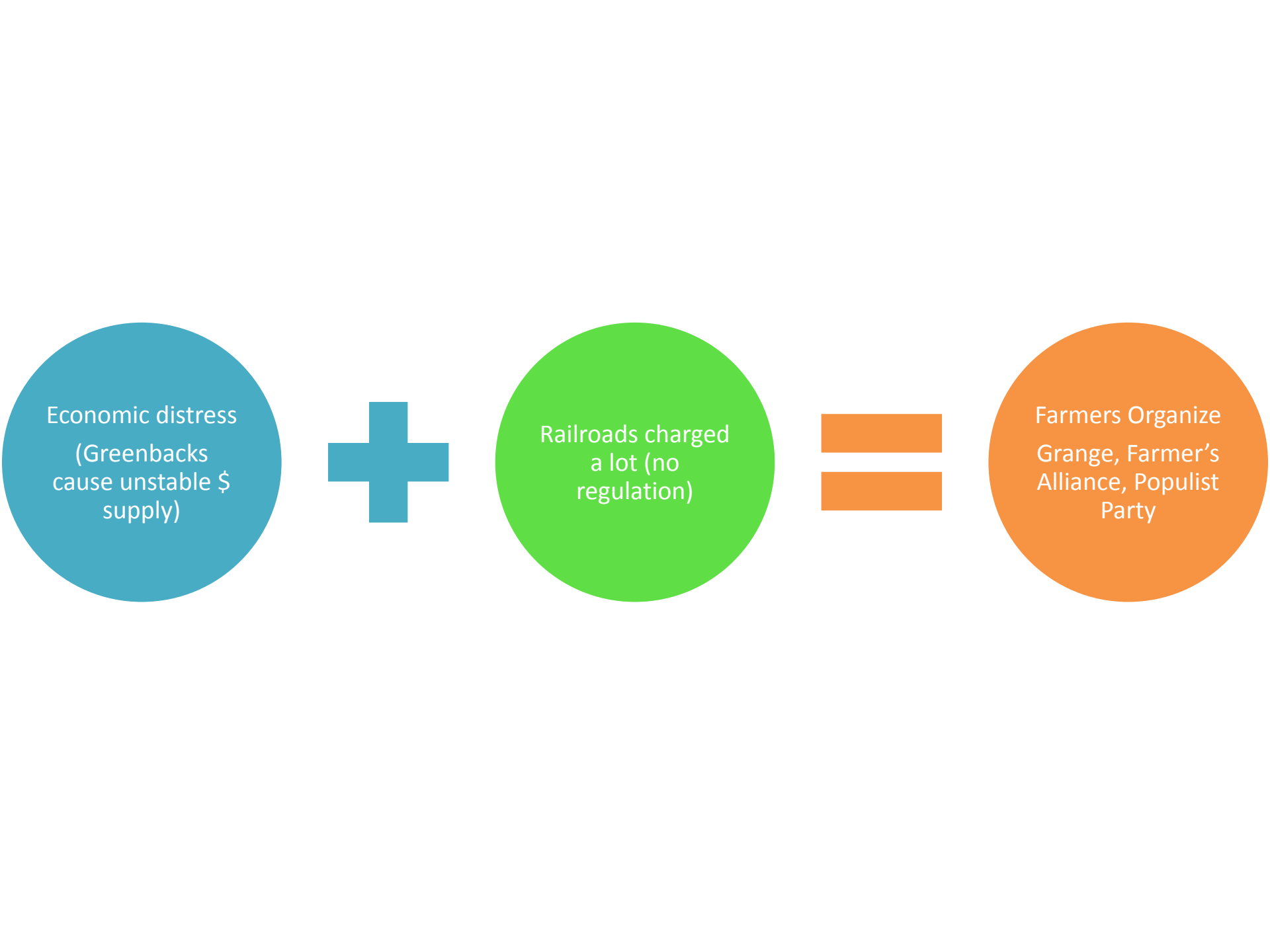
**Why did farmers want more money
in circulation?
How would they benefit?**



Economics Nationwide

- Farmers believed if more money was in circulation it would make the \$ in circulation worth less
 - Helping them pay off loans
- Railroad companies increased prices
 - This influenced market prices of crops
 - No regulation by the government
 - Monopolize the industry
 - More expensive to ship from the Dakotas to MN than Chicago to London





Economic distress
(Greenbacks
cause unstable \$
supply)



Railroads charged
a lot (no
regulation)



Farmers Organize
Grange, Farmer's
Alliance, Populist
Party

Farmers Organize

- The Grange-1867
 - Social Outlet
 - Educational Forum
 - Focused on isolated farmers
- Farmers Alliance-1875
 - Improve economic conditions for farmers
 - Cooperation & Political Advocacy
- Populist Party-1892



Populism

- Movement of the people
- Starts in Omaha, Nebraska in 1892
- Reforms
- Lift burden of debt from farmers
- Populism attracted: farmers, silverites & people in favor of regulating the Railroad



Populist Party Platform

- Limit immigration
- Direct election of Senators
- Single term President/VP
- Railroad Regulation
- Increase \$ supply
- Federal Loan Program
- Graduated Income Tax
- 8 hour workday



Silverites

- Farmers, laborers
- South & West
- Democrats
- Bimetallism-silver & gold to back money supply
- Print more money (increase supply)
- Stimulate the economy

Goldbugs

- Business & Industrial
- Northeast
- Republicans
- Gold Standard: only use gold to back money supply
- More stable



People regarded paper \$ as worthless if it couldn't be turned in for coin

Gold bugs/Silverites

**Now read the section from
the textbook on your
assignment.**



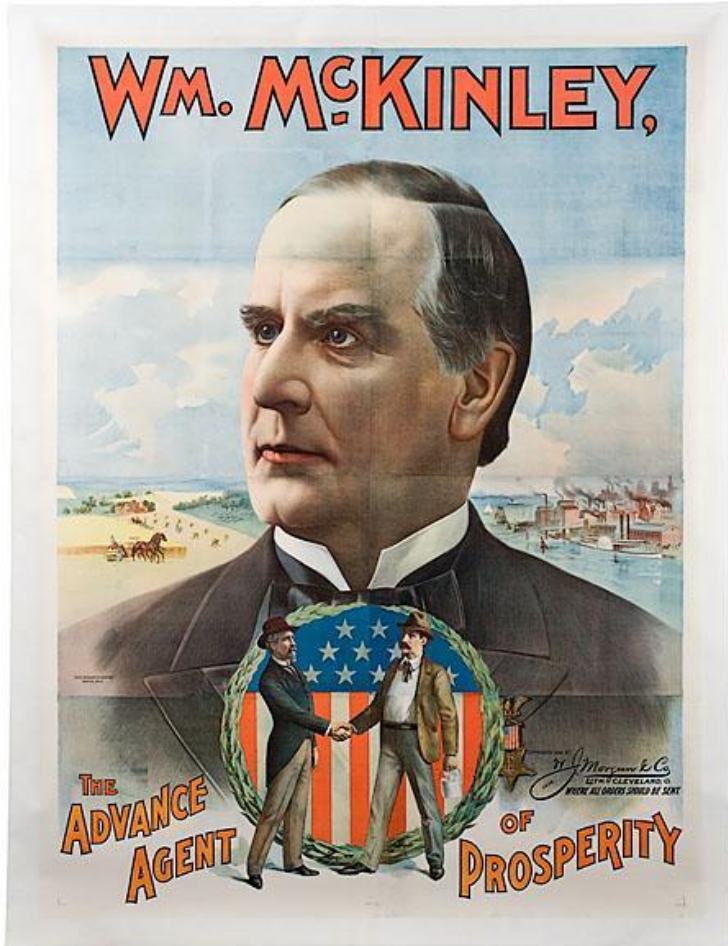
- More silver than gold, more money in circulation
- Presidential Election of 1896
 - Silverites, led by William Jennings Bryan, wanted gold and silver
 - Democrats / Populists
 - Gold bugs, led by William McKinley, wanted just gold to back the paper money
 - Republicans
- Bryan's "Cross of Gold" speech

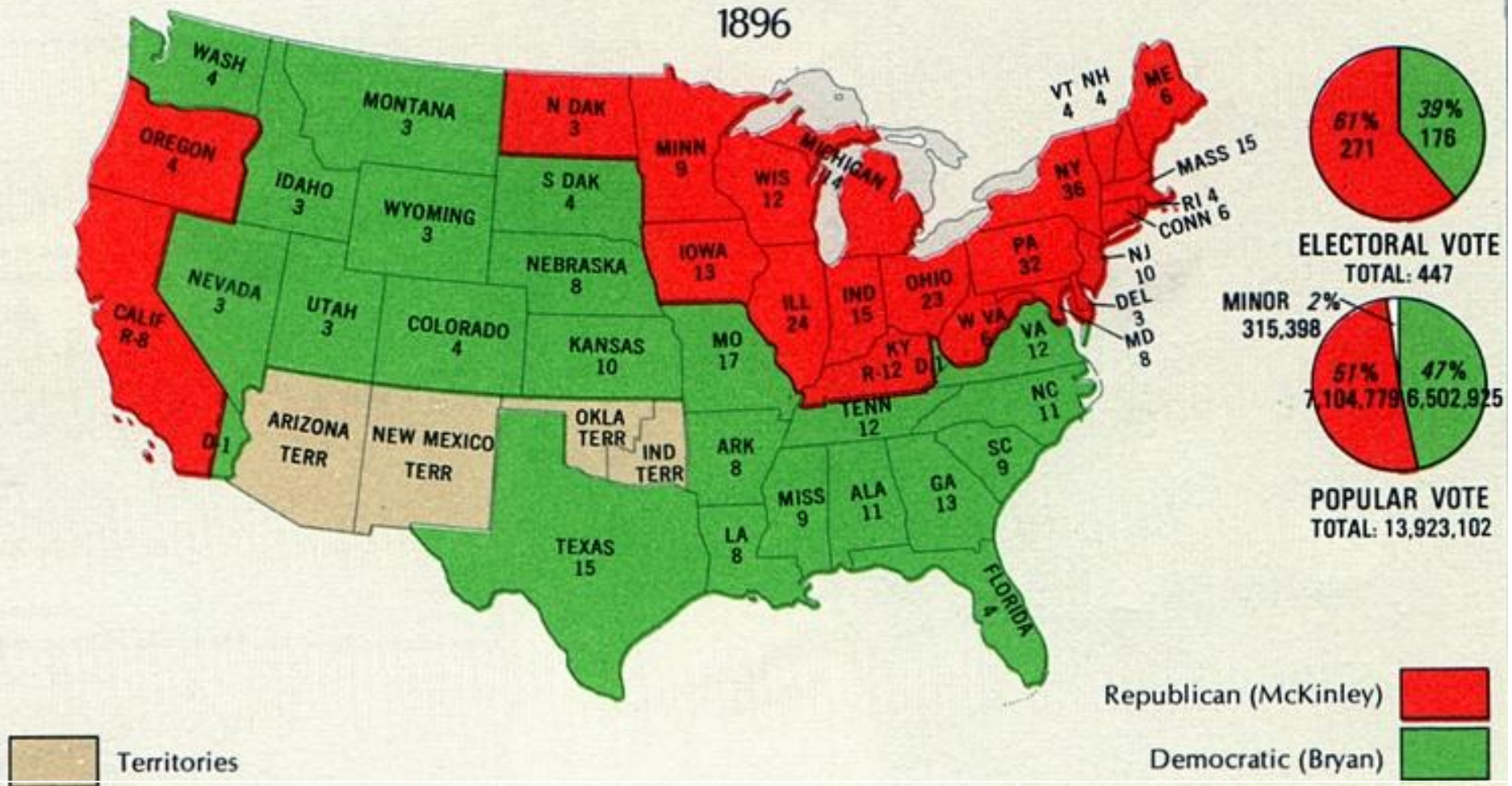


William Jennings Bryan



William McKinley





- City dwellers (industry) were afraid of inflation-overwhelmingly voted for McKinley

- McKinley won the election 7 million to Bryan's 6.5 million
- McKinley carried the East & urban Midwest
- Bryan carried the South and farm West---agriculture

Failed to win elections, but many of their goals do happen in the 20th Century

Wizard of Oz and Populism

Does the Wizard of Oz have a hidden meaning?

